

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

God only shows up in premises (2) and (5). Let's look at what happens if we replace reference to God's foreknowledge with reference to there being truths about our future actions.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
 - 2*. In the past, there were truths about all of our future actions.
 3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)
 4. If we have no choice about p, and no choice about the fact that if p, then q, then we have no choice about q.
 - 5*. We have no choice about the fact that if it is true that I will perform some action, then I will perform that action.
-

C. We have no choice about whether we will perform our future actions.
(3,4,5)

The fatalist argument

Let's turn to the question of how the believer in free will might reply to these arguments.

First, let's list the substantial assumptions
which are common to both arguments.

There are truths
about our future
actions.

We have no
choice about the
past.

If we have no
choice about some
facts, and those
facts necessitate
X, we have no
choice about X.

There is also one substantial assumption
made only by the Foreknowledge
Argument:

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

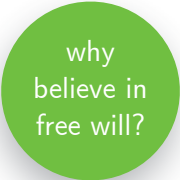
Let's begin with this one, before turning to the assumptions common to both arguments.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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Suppose that someone did not believe in

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Edwards' argument — but did believe that

similar to Edwards' argument?

with reference to the being of truth about

God only shows up in premises (2) and

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.



2*In the past, there were truths about

then we have the choice about q.

1. We have no direct facts.

all of our activities.

3 We have not the fact that

5* We have noticed that the fact

that if it is true that I will perform

God knows that in the future I will

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

(3, 4, 5)



4. If we have no choice about p , and no

0 We have achieved what we

will perform various actions.

some action, then I will prefer that

perform a certain action (1,2)

acaioid.

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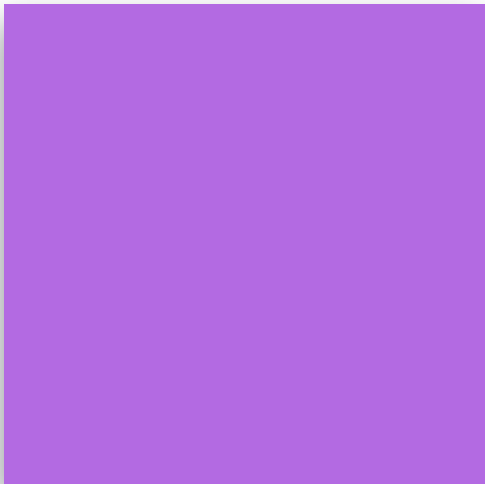




There is also one substantial assumption

Argument:

made only by the Foreknowledge



Let's begin with this

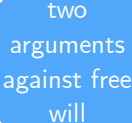
the assumptions



arguments.



one, before turning to



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that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

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